MODERN GUERRILLA FIGHTERS

In the 1930s Mao Zedong in China formulated the theory of rural-based guerrilla war as the path to communist revolution. His triumph in China in 1949 and the subsequent defeat of France by Viet Minh guerrillas in Vietnam in 1954 was followed by victory for Fidel Castro's armed band in Cuba in 1959. By the 1960s the United States regarded counterinsurgency warfare as crucial to preventing the spread of communism in the Cold War. Yet from the late 1970s America itself backed guerrilla forces in wars against left-wing governments in Afghanistan, Angola, and Nicaragua. By the 21st century, guerrilla activity had in some countries degenerated into permanent warfare between armed gangs, existing in symbiosis with the international narcotics trade.

MUJAHIDEEN IN THE 1980S

In 1978 insurgent groups opposed to the pro-Soviet Marxist government of Afghanistan began training at bases in Pakistan. From the summer of 1979 these mujahideen (or "those who struggle") were backed by the American CIA as well as by Pakistani secret services. In December 1979 the Soviet Union sent troops into Afghanistan to counter the burgeoning insurgency. The guerrillas who took on the Soviet forces consisted mostly of local tribesmen operating in groups a few hundred strong. In the course of the war, links between guerrilla groups developed until they were able to mount operations involving as many as 10,000 men. The mujahideen maintained a campaign of hit-and-run raids in the face of intensive Soviet counterinsurgency operations, exploiting their knowledge of the mountainous terrain, but were unsuccessful when they attempted to overrun urban areas. They obtained weapons chiefly from the US, Saudi Arabia, Iran, and China, funnelled into Afghanistan via Islamic parties in Pakistan, which claimed leadership of the insurrection. Arab Islamic fundamentalists, including Saudi businessman Osama bin Laden, also became involved in the conflict. From 1985 the mujahideen were supplied with American Stinger and British Blowpipe anti-aircraft missiles, which reduced the effectiveness of Soviet helicopters. The Soviets never controlled much of Afghanistan outside the towns and pulled out their troops in 1988–89, having suffered 64,000 casualties.



RPG-7
This Russian-made rocket launcher was regularly used against Soviet forces in Afghanistan.

Asymmetric warfare
Afghan mujahideen stand on the remains of a Russian helicopter brought down by an American-supplied Stinger surface-to-air missile.